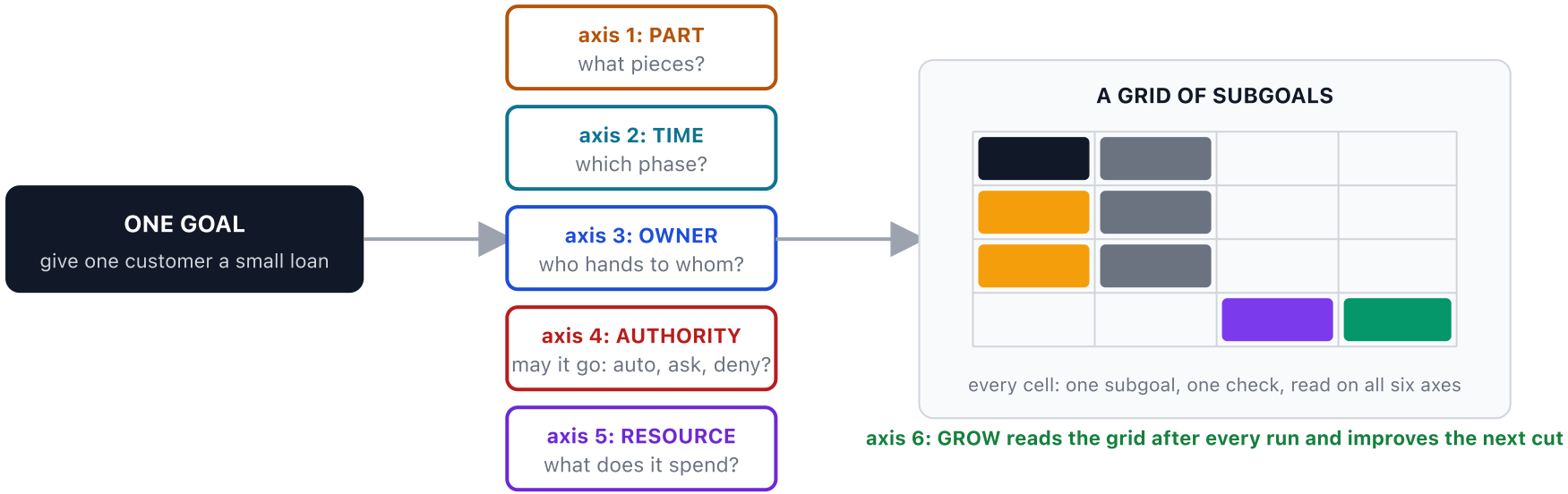
One goal, cut into subgoals

How a company turns one line of intent into work it can run, check and improve. One small lending goal, cut along one axis at a time, until all six questions of the compass have been asked. Nothing here needs prior knowledge of the system.



STEP 0

The goal, and the rule of the cut

Everything starts from one line with its own check. The cut has one rule: keep cutting until each piece has one goal and one check and cannot be split and still be work. That smallest piece is a **work atom**.

THE GOAL

Give one customer a small personal loan.

Check: the money is in the customer's account within 2 working days, and every step is on record.

THE RULE OF THE CUT

1. Choose an axis: the question you cut on.
2. Cut the goal into pieces along it.
3. Each piece gets one goal and one check.
4. Stop when a piece cannot be split and still be work.
5. Add the next axis; the pieces become a grid.

THE SIX QUESTIONS (the compass)

SHAPE what pieces, cut fresh from this ask?
TIME when, and on what beat?
EDGE who hands what to whom?
GOVERN may this step go: auto, ask or deny?
RESOURCE what finite stock does it spend?
GROW what has the record taught, across runs?

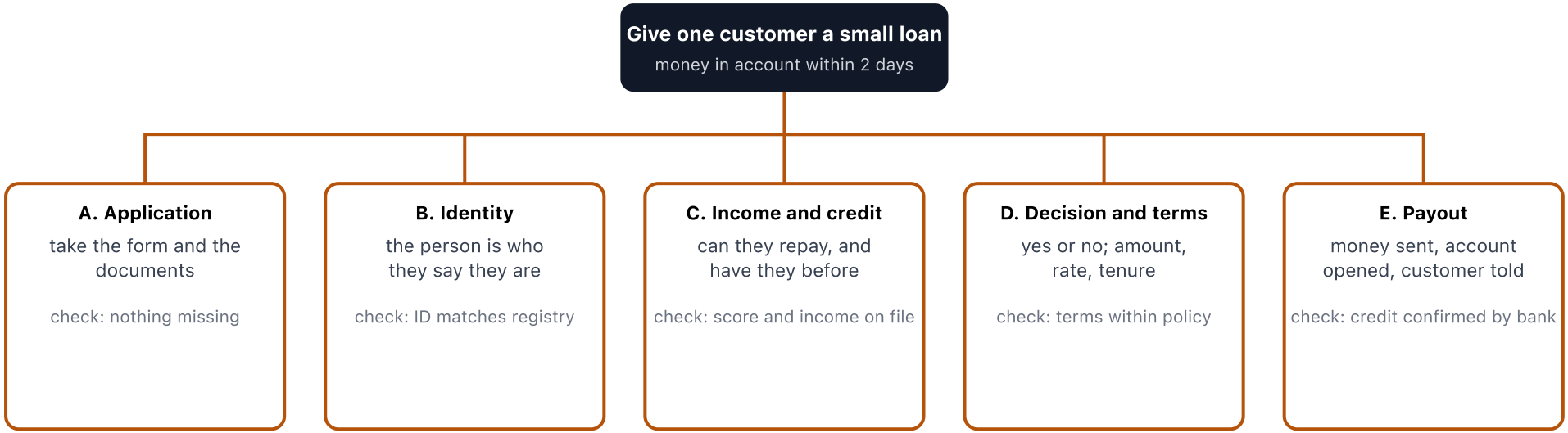
We start with the two easiest to see, PART and TIME, because a person can draw them on paper. The other four are added one at a time on the same grid.

AXIS 1 OF 6

PART: what pieces does the goal have?

SHAPE: part | TIME | EDGE | GOVERN | RESOURCE | GROW

The first cut follows the natural seams of the work. Five pieces, each with its own check. This is the cut a branch manager would make on a whiteboard.



Each box is still too big to run: "Identity" is several actions. The next axis splits them further without inventing new pieces.

AXIS 2 OF 6

TIME: in which phase does each piece happen?

SHAPE: part | TIME: phase | EDGE | GOVERN | RESOURCE | GROW

Cross the five parts with four phases and the pieces become a grid of subgoals. Each filled cell is one subgoal with one check. Empty cells are honest: no work lives there.

PART \ TIME	1. Apply (day 0)	2. Check (day 0 to 1)	3. Decide (day 1)	4. Pay out (day 1 to 2)
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** check: form complete, 3 documents in	**A2. Ask for anything missing** check: the missing item named, customer told	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** check: a readable ID on file	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** check: match confirmed, or mismatch named	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** check: 6 months on file	**C2. Read the statements, pull the bureau score** check: income and score on file, or a reason	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** check: terms within policy	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** check: agreement matches the terms	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** check: bank confirms the credit

11 subgoals, 9 empty cells. Two axes were enough to make the goal runnable.

AXIS 3 OF 6

OWNER: who does each cell, and who hands to whom?

SHAPE: part | TIME: phase | EDGE: owner, hand-off | GOVERN | RESOURCE | GROW

Same grid, one colour added. Now every cell has a hand and every border between two colours is a hand-off the system must record.

PART \ TIME	1. Apply (day 0)	2. Check (day 0 to 1)	3. Decide (day 1)	4. Pay out (day 1 to 2)
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** check: form complete, 3 documents in officer	**A2. Ask for anything missing** check: the missing item named, customer told officer	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** check: a readable ID on file customer	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** check: match confirmed, or mismatch named system	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** check: 6 months on file customer	**C2. Read the statements, pull the bureau score** check: income and score on file, or a reason system	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** check: terms within policy credit desk	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** check: agreement matches the terms system	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** check: bank confirms the credit finance

customer | branch officer | the system (an agent) | credit desk | finance | hand-offs on this grid: customer to officer, officer to system, system to credit desk, credit desk to finance

EDGE reads the link between two cells, never the cell itself. Four links, four places work can get stuck.

AXIS 4 OF 6

AUTHORITY: may this cell go on its own, or must someone stamp it?

SHAPE: part | TIME: phase | EDGE: owner | GOVERN: auto / ask / deny | RESOURCE | GROW

One more reading per cell. Most cells run on their own. Two cells ask for a stamp. One cell can stop the whole goal.

PART \ TIME	1. Apply (day 0)	2. Check (day 0 to 1)	3. Decide (day 1)	4. Pay out (day 1 to 2)
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** check: form complete, 3 documents in officer · auto	**A2. Ask for anything missing** check: the missing item named, customer told officer · auto	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** check: a readable ID on file customer · auto	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** check: match confirmed, or mismatch named system · deny	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** check: 6 months on file customer · auto	**C2. Read the statements, pull the bureau score** check: income and score on file, or a reason system · auto	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** check: terms within policy credit desk · ask	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** check: agreement matches the terms system · auto	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** check: bank confirms the credit finance · ask

auto: runs on its own ask: a person stamps first deny: the goal stops here if the check fails

RESOURCE and the beat: what each cell spends, and by when

SHAPE: part | TIME: phase, deadline | EDGE: owner | GOVERN | RESOURCE: minutes, calls | GROW

Two numbers per cell: person-minutes and system calls. TIME returns with a deadline per phase. Now the goal has a cost and a clock, and both can be read back after the run.

PART \ TIME	1. Apply (day 0) by end of day 0	2. Check (day 0 to 1) within 4 hours	3. Decide (day 1) within 1 working day	4. Pay out (day 1 to 2) within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** check: form complete, 3 documents in officer · auto 4 min, 1 call	**A2. Ask for anything missing** check: the missing item named, customer told officer · auto 2 min, 1 call	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** check: a readable ID on file customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** check: match confirmed, or mismatch named system · deny 0 min, 2 calls	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** check: 6 months on file customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	**C2. Read the statements, pull the bureau score** check: income and score on file, or a reason system · auto 0 min, 6 calls	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** check: terms within policy credit desk · ask 8 min, 1 call	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** check: agreement matches the terms system · auto 0 min, 2 calls	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** check: bank confirms the credit finance · ask 5 min, 1 call

Run total: 22 person-minutes, 14 system calls, 2 working days.

The scarcest stock is the owner's attention: the two asks are where it goes.

GROW: after 40 loans, the record changes the grid

SHAPE | TIME | EDGE | GOVERN | RESOURCE | GROW: what the record taught

GROW does not cut. It reads the 40 runs and lifts what repeated into a rule, a template or a frozen step. The next loan is cut the same way but runs cheaper and asks less.

PART \ TIME	1. Apply (day 0) by end of day 0	2. Check (day 0 to 1) within 4 hours	3. Decide (day 1) within 1 working day	4. Pay out (day 1 to 2) within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** check: form complete, 3 documents in officer · auto 4 min, 1 call	**A2. Ask for anything missing** check: the missing item named, customer told officer · auto 2 min, 1 call template learned: the missing-document ask	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** check: a readable ID on file customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** check: match confirmed, or mismatch named system · deny 0 min, 2 calls	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** check: 6 months on file customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	**C2. Read the statements, pull the bureau score** check: income and score on file, or a reason system · auto 0 min, 6 calls	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** check: terms within policy credit desk · ask 8 min, 1 call rule learned: under 1 lakh with score above 750 is auto	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** check: agreement matches the terms system · auto 0 min, 2 calls	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** check: bank confirms the credit finance · ask 5 min, 1 call

frozen to code: same result 40 of 40 times, now near free warm: the system does it, a person watches hot: a person decides every time

GROW accumulates on the unit across runs. Realization slid right: 2 of 5 system cells are code now. Reflection lifted one repeated stamp into a rule.

ALL SIX AT ONCE

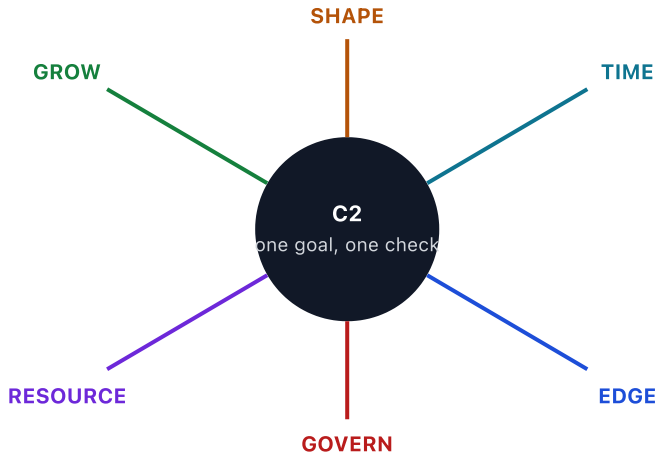
One cell, read on all six axes

Take one subgoal, "read the bank statements and pull the bureau score". It is not six things; it is one thing with six readings. This is what the system reads on every cell, every run.

SUBGOAL C2

Read the bank statements and pull the bureau score.

Check: 6 months of income on file and a score, or a named reason why not.



SHAPE

cut by part, phase Check; ground is complicated (partial payments need a closer look), so posture is analyze, not just do

TIME

phase 2 of 4; within 4 hours of the documents arriving; the bureau sensor is re-tested nightly

EDGE

receives the statements from the customer (C1); hands income and score to the decision (D3); a shared lock with any other loan for the same customer

GOVERN

auto; deny if no score can be pulled; a human never reads raw statements unless this cell asks

RESOURCE

0 person-minutes, 6 system calls; the costliest cell in the run until it freezes

GROW

warm after 40 runs; variance low on salaried customers, so a split is proposed: salaried freezes to code, self-employed stays warm

Every cell on every grid carries these six readings. That is the whole compass, applied.

DO IT YOURSELF

How to cut any goal, in five moves

1. **Write the goal in one line, with its check.** If you cannot say how you would know it is done, it is a wish, not a goal.
2. **Cut on PART.** Follow the natural seams. Give each piece one goal and one check. Stop when a piece cannot split and still be work.
3. **Cut on TIME.** Put each piece in its phase. Leave empty cells empty.
4. **Add one reading at a time:** OWNER (who, and the hand-offs), AUTHORITY (auto, ask, deny), RESOURCE (what it spends, by when).
5. **Run it, read every cell, and let GROW change the next cut.** A step that never varies freezes. A stamp given the same way ten times becomes a rule. A pain that repeats grows a new management rung.

WHY TWO AXES FIRST

PART and TIME are the two anyone can draw. They make the goal runnable on their own. The other four do not add pieces; they add readings to the pieces that exist.

WHY THE FAMILIES ARE SIX AND CLOSED

Every question you can ask of work sorts into one of them: reads the input fresh (SHAPE), accumulates on the unit (GROW), gates a step (GOVERN), reads a link (EDGE), spends a stock (RESOURCE), is about when (TIME). New axes are minted freely inside a family; the six do not change.

THE PROMISE

First run expensive, every run cheaper. Not a hope: the grid records every cell, and GROW reads the record.

Source: Native, the compass (axes and families); the department PRD, "one workflow read along five axes". Draft, 2026-10-12.